

Assignment 1: Community Profile

(Due in Quercus on Monday, October 6, by 11:59 PM)

Congratulations! You are now working for Toronto's planning department. City decisionmakers want to understand the concentrations that make your neighborhood unique, as well as recent neighborhood changes. Working with one of your colleagues, your first assignment on the job is to prepare a community profile:

1. of census tract _____ as of 2021
2. of notable changes in demographic and housing characteristics in your census tract between 2006 and 2021;
3. that compares census tract changes to changes for the city or CMA as a whole;
4. that identifies at least one key issue in the tract using evidence from the census.

The planning commissioners in your city are very busy and have a short attention span. For students working in pairs, they've requested that your community profile not exceed ten pages (1.5 spaces), 12 point font, *including* text, tables, charts, and maps – with a minimum of eight pages. For students working alone, the requirement is 6-8 pages (1.5 spaces). (But either way you can have an appendix). Documents should be submitted online in Word or as a PDF.

Among the variables they are interested in for your tract (using census data) are:

1. number of people and households
2. age structure of the population
3. household type and composition
4. visible minority and/or ethnic composition
5. income and poverty levels
6. educational attainment
7. labor force characteristics (industry or occupation)
8. composition of the housing stock (e.g., use, tenure, cost, stability)
9. physical characteristics of the housing stock (e.g., structure type, age)
10. journey-to-work travel characteristics

Two-person groups are expected to analyze **at least eight** of these variables in some form (i.e., 2021 alone, 2006-2021 changes, and/or tract vs. city or CMA). One-person groups must analyze **at least six**. You may also choose to add additional variables. For your longitudinal and cross-sectional comparisons, the commissioners want you to choose the

variables you think are most relevant to your neighborhood and to the story you want to tell about it. They also want you to speculate about the potential impacts of the pandemic on the census data collection in 2021. And **be sure to include a location map** to show where your tract is within Toronto!

Once you have looked through all the data and have a good sense of what is going on in your tract, figure out a story to focus on. Some examples of patterns to build a story around (these are just examples, not a recipe – please find your own stories!). (*Note that we are not asking you to conduct any advanced statistical analysis such as correlation or regression – that comes later in the class.*)

- Aging of the population in place, decreases of school-age children, implications for school enrollment
- Transition from family to nonfamily households, rise of alternative housing arrangements, implication for housing demand
- Ethnic transition, rise of non-English-speaking households, and implications for the workforce
- Increases in education and income of residents, change in housing prices, and possible onset of gentrification
- New housing construction (or lack of it), changes in housing prices, and implications for affordability
- High level of commute flows, high reliance on rail transit, and implications for local housing demand
- Concentration of local bars and restaurants, influx of students, and implications for bike travel

What should your profile focus on?

1. The basics: How many people lived in your tract, their ages, household composition, and race in 2021? What were the income, education, labor force, commuting, and housing stock characteristics 2021?
2. Notable changes: in age, household, racial distributions? Any other variables?
3. Census tract vs. city or CMA: notable differences between your census tract and city in 2021.
4. Comparative changes: changes in your census tract that mirror or depart from socio-demographic changes for the city or CMA as a whole.
5. The story: For the story you identify for your tract, conduct a more in-depth analysis using one or more indicators of your choice. Are there important relationships among the variables (for instance, is new housing unit construction accompanied by an influx of high-skilled residents)?

6. *The pandemic*: How might the results be impacted

How to organize your profile?

1. Introduction: Identify your tract and city/CMA, and explain which findings, trends, variables, or issues you will focus on and why. Feel free to draw on current media stories that describe the issue you will be discussing.
2. Explanation and analysis of findings and trends organized by characteristic (e.g., age distribution, housing stock, etc.), and within the characteristic, the important themes (big 2006-2021 changes, big difference with city, etc.).
3. The interesting story: For the main story you have chosen, summarize the evidence (from the census) on the phenomenon.
4. Conclusion: Very brief summary of key findings.
5. Appendix (optional): You may find it useful to include a data table in an appendix.
6. Bibliography – not needed!!

NOTE: Be sure to include tables, charts, and maps. But don't overdo it. Not every number or percentage needs an exhibit. Nor do all of the outputs need to be presented. Figure out what your main points are and use tables, charts (don't forget error bars!), maps, and text, as appropriate, to illustrate them. And keep it simple...tell the story of your neighborhood organized along some important themes.

Grading Criteria

- Accuracy of data and analysis -- 40%
- Nailing the story of your tract -- 25%
- Presenting appropriate and aesthetically pleasing visualizations -- 25%
- Following the assignment guidelines -- 10%